

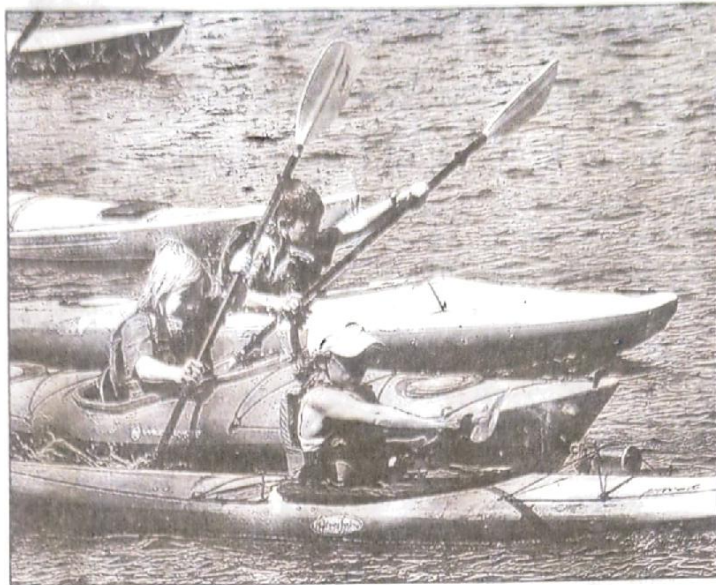


PHOTO COURTESY OF CATAWBA RIVERFEST

Children compete in kayak race at previous festival.

Raptor release planned for RiverFest

Event will be Sept. 18 at Lake James State Park

From staff reports

NEBO — The Carolina Raptor Center will bring hawks, owls and eagles to the 7th annual Catawba RiverFest and will release a raptor back into the wild.

RiverFest is Sept. 18 from 10 a.m. to 3 p.m. at Lake James State Park.

Organizers say the community event aims to promote a greater appreciation of the vital resource.

"The Catawba River has shaped the economic vitality of the region and remains a public commons of immeasurable value," RiverFest officials said in a news release.

"However, today the river faces competing interests. The Catawba River supports multiple uses including power generation, public water supply, waste assimilation and recreation, as well as habitat for many populations of aquatic life.

"With increasing attention on the Catawba River's challenges, efforts are under way to protect this valuable natural resource."

The event will highlight projects and groups working to improve the quality of life along the river.

RiverFest will be at the new Paddy's Creek section of Lake James State Park, about three miles east of the current park, on N.C. 126.

Paddy's Creek includes a 700-foot

swim beach, concession stand, 6,000-square-foot bathhouse, two picnic shelters, individual picnic sites, three miles of hiking trails and a 450-space parking lot.

A water derby is also planned for midday that will involve an obstacle course and a lake race. Prizes for the derby will be offered in part by CBS Sports of Morganton. Visitors are encouraged to bring their canoes and kayaks for the competition that is open to all ages and levels of experience.

There will be a raffle for prizes including a kayak. Tickets can be purchased at the event and at CBS Sports.

Sponsors of the free festival include Lake James State Park, Catawba Valley Heritage Alliance, Catawba Riverkeepers, Duke Energy and Western Piedmont Council of Governments.

Exhibitors include Catawba Science Center, Friends of Lake James State Park, N.C. Wildlife Resources Commission, The Foothills Conservancy, Carolina Reptile Rescue and Education Center, McDowell Trails Association, Lake James Environmental Association and others.

Food will be available for purchase. Strictly Clean and Decent of Lenoir is scheduled to perform.

For more information, go to www.heritagealliance.org or call 465-2755.